

HANDLING TOUGH SITUATIONS IN A HEALTHY WAY # 38

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Accept responsibility for legal problems without blaming others.
2. Learn to cope with the uncertainty that is associated with legal problems.
3. Create a plan to cope with each possible legal outcome.
4. Identify nonaddictive coping strategies to deal with any outcome of legal problems.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE LEGAL PROBLEMS

- Barriers and Solutions
- Consequences of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- What Do I Need and How Do I Get It?
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?
- What's Addiction Got to Do with My Problems?

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Handling Tough Situations in a Healthy Way” activity is designed for the client who is having difficulty coping with current legal issues (pending or resolved) or old legal issues that have been left unresolved. It can be an adjunct activity to basic problem-solving strategies or to a cost/benefit analysis.

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A big part of recovery from addictions, and a healthy coping skill, is taking responsibility for past and current behaviors. If you have worked or are working a 12-step program, this is also part of your 12-step work. Handling legal problems without resorting to old, negative coping patterns is a vital part of your recovery. Sometimes the outcome of legal issues is not in our hands, and we must learn to deal with the possibility of serious consequences (e.g., prison time) without returning to addictive behaviors. Other times the consequences of legal situations are known—fines, child support/alimony, loss of a driver's license, and so on. Whether the outcome is known or unknown, you may feel anxiety, worry, depression, confusion, guilt, shame, fear, and a host of other emotions. Handling pending, current, or unresolved legal situations in healthy ways is possible by using new skills. The goal of this exercise is to help you look at legal issues you face, explore your feelings about them, identify some techniques to help cope with those legal issues, and begin to plan to maintain your recovery no matter what happens.

1. List the legal charges you have pending, your known current legal issues, and the legal issues that have not been resolved.

2. What are the known consequences for each item you've listed in question 1 (e.g., jail, criminal record, stigma, court-ordered treatment, probation, parole)?

3. What are your worries and fears about your pending legal issues or the legal issues you have not resolved?

4. With whom could you consult to get more information and insight regarding what you are facing (e.g., probation office, attorney, police, court official)?

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5. For each legal issue that you have pending or unresolved, what would be the best and worst possible outcome? For all the outcomes you've outlined, what is a strategy to deal with each?

Legal Issue	Best Outcome	Worst Outcome	Strategy

6. How can you begin to assume responsibility for your legal problems? Name one action you can take for each legal problem.

7. How does failing to address these unresolved legal issues put you at risk for relapse?

8. List five ways you can show you are taking responsibility for your life in spite of the current uncertainty.

9. Please use this space to describe a beginning plan for how you will cope with possible painful consequences of future legal problems without relapsing.

10. How would you benefit from living life without the stress of legal problems?

11. Talk with some people you know who have had legal problems and resolved them without returning to addictive behaviors. Ask them how they were able to do it and write three things they

did that you think could work for you in dealing with your current legal issues.
